ADMIRAL BYRD

AND THE HIDDEN REALM

Written by
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Inspired by the legend of Admiral Richard E. Byrd's
"lost diary"

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FADE IN:

INT. NAVY DEPARTMENT - MAP ROOM - DAY

SUPER: "WASHINGTON, D.C. - NOVEMBER 1946"

CLOSE ON a map of Antarctica. Coastlines inked in careful detail. But the middle of the continent is a vast white emptiness, stamped with one word:

UNEXPLORED.

A weathered finger touches the blank. Rests there.

PULL BACK to reveal REAR ADMIRAL RICHARD E. BYRD (58). Silver hair, a matinee idol gone craggy, a Medal of Honor ribbon on his chest. He is the most famous explorer alive, and he knows it.

Around a long table: VICE ADMIRAL CONRAD PRESCOTT (60s, all jaw), a dozen STAFF OFFICERS, a scale model of an aircraft carrier, and enough cigarette smoke to hide a submarine.

PRESCOTT
Thirteen ships. Forty-seven hundred men. Thirty-three aircraft. Operation Highjump will be the largest expedition ever sent to the Antarctic.

STAFF OFFICER
Primary objective: train personnel and test equipment in extreme cold.

PRESCOTT
In case we ever have to fight somewhere cold.

Every eye drifts to a second map on the wall: the Soviet Union, enormous and red.

BYRD
And the interior?

PRESCOTT
The what?

BYRD
(tapping the blank)
There's a hole in that map bigger than the United States, Conrad. And we're sending forty-seven hundred men to go practice standing in the cold next to it.

PRESCOTT
That's exactly what we're doing.
(beat)
Dick. The country loves you. Your job is the newsreels. Wave from the ship. Look windswept.

A PHOTOGRAPHER pushes forward with a Speed Graphic camera.

PHOTOGRAPHER
Admiral, could you point at the map? Heroically?

Byrd hesitates. Then the old showman takes over. Chin up. Finger aimed at the blank like a sword.

FLASH.

The bulb pops. The officers applaud politely. Byrd holds the pose a moment too long, smiling a smile that does not reach his eyes.

INT. NAVY DEPARTMENT - CORRIDOR - CONTINUOUS

Byrd strides out. A WAVE and a YOUNG SAILOR stop him with notebooks. He signs both with a flourish. He enjoys this. He always has.

YOUNG SAILOR
I read all your books, sir!

BYRD
Then you're one of the six.

He keeps walking. A woman falls into step beside him, carrying a cardboard box overflowing with charts and spools of wire.

DR. EVELYN MARCH (34). Ink on her fingers, pencil in her hair, the restless energy of someone who has been told "no" for a living.

EVELYN
Admiral Byrd. I've been trying to get into that room for three weeks.

A MARINE GUARD moves to block her. Byrd waves him off without breaking stride.

BYRD
And you are?

EVELYN
Dr. Evelyn March. Naval Research Laboratory. Geophysics.

BYRD
The Navy has lady geophysicists?

EVELYN
The Navy has one. It mostly uses her to make coffee.
(beat)
Your blank isn't blank, Admiral. Something under the ice is bending the Earth's magnetic field. And it moves.

BYRD
Ice moves, Doctor. That's what ice does.

EVELYN
Ice doesn't sing.

Byrd stops walking.

INT. NAVY DEPARTMENT - EMPTY OFFICE - MOMENTS LATER

Dust sheets on the furniture. Evelyn spreads magnetic charts across a desk: rings of numbers swirling around a point deep in the white heart of Antarctica, like water around a drain.

EVELYN
Magnetic readings from three expeditions, including two of yours. The anomaly shifts a few miles every year. Nothing natural does that.

She threads a spool onto a battered WIRE RECORDER.

EVELYN (CONT'D)
And in July, a radioman at a Navy listening station picked up this. Very faint. Coming from the bottom of the world.

BYRD
In July.

EVELYN
July second, 1946. The day after we tested the atomic bomb at Bikini.

That lands. Byrd looks at her for a long moment.

She switches on the recorder.

Hiss. Crackle. And then, underneath, a SOUND. Low. Layered. Like a choir humming through a mile of ice. It rises, falls, rises again. Almost a melody.

Byrd goes pale. His hand finds the edge of the desk.

The hum swells, and swallows the room, and we --

MATCH CUT TO:

INT. ADVANCE BASE - ANTARCTICA - NIGHT (FLASHBACK)

SUPER: "ADVANCE BASE, ANTARCTICA - 1934"

A hut the size of a closet, buried under the ice. Frost furs every surface. A single oil stove ticks and wheezes.

BYRD (45), bearded, hollow-eyed, alone, sits wrapped in furs. He is writing by lantern light.

INSERT - THE PAGE

"My dearest Marie. If you are reading this, then..."

BACK TO SCENE

He coughs. The pen slips. The lantern flame doubles, triples. The stove fumes are stealing the air from the room.

Byrd lurches up, reaching for the frozen hatch overhead. His fingers can't find the handle. His knees fold. He crashes to the floor.

The lantern gutters. Darkness.

Then -- the HUM. The same impossible chord.

A thin line of GOLDEN LIGHT traces the edges of the hatch. The ice around it sweats and melts.

The hatch swings open from the outside. Snow and clean, freezing air pour in.

A FIGURE kneels in the doorway, silhouetted in the gold. Impossibly tall. Impossibly slender. A long hand reaches down and rests on Byrd's forehead. Faint patterns of light ripple across its fingers.

BYRD
(barely a whisper)
Who's there?

The figure hums. One soft note.

The light fades.

INT. ADVANCE BASE - LATER

Byrd wakes on the floor. Grey daylight through the open hatch. The stove is off. He is breathing.

He drags himself up the ladder and looks out.

EXT. ADVANCE BASE - CONTINUOUS

Endless white. Wind. Nobody.

At the edge of the hatch, one FOOTPRINT. Long. Narrow. Far too long. Already filling with drifting snow.

Byrd stares at it until the wind erases it completely.

SMASH CUT TO:

INT. NAVY DEPARTMENT - EMPTY OFFICE - DAY (PRESENT)

Byrd snaps off the wire recorder. His hand is shaking.

EVELYN
Admiral?

BYRD
I've heard that sound before.

EVELYN
Where?

BYRD
Advance Base. Thirty-four. I was alone down there for five months. Stove leaked. I nearly died.

EVELYN
I read your book. "Alone."

BYRD
Then you read the parts I put in it.
(beat)
The doctors said the fumes made me see things. Maybe they did. But I heard that hum, Doctor, and somebody opened that door. I left it out of the book. A man who says he saw angels in the ice doesn't get funded twice.

EVELYN
I don't think it was an angel.

BYRD
Neither do I.

He gathers up her charts, rolls them tight, and tucks them under his arm.

BYRD (CONT'D)
Dr. March, how would you like to go to Antarctica?

EVELYN
They will never let a woman --

BYRD
Leave the Navy to me.

INT. NAVY DEPARTMENT - PRESCOTT'S OFFICE - DAY

Prescott reads Evelyn's report with the expression of a man reading a ransom note.

PRESCOTT
A long-range flight. Into the blank. On the word of a lady scientist and a noise on a wire.

BYRD
On my word, Conrad.

PRESCOTT
Your word got you to the North Pole.
(beat)
Allegedly.

That one stings. Byrd's jaw tightens.

PRESCOTT (CONT'D)
The answer is no. The fuel alone --

MAN (O.S.)
I'd let him go, Admiral.

They turn. In the corner, half-hidden by a potted fern, a MAN IN A GREY SUIT has been sitting so still they forgot he was there.

MR. WARREN STILES (40s). Neat. Polite. Eyes like two shut doors.

STILES
Warren Stiles. Central Intelligence Group.

BYRD
Never heard of it.

STILES
That's the idea.

(standing)
We've been tracking that signal too, Admiral. Our analysts think the Soviets have built a station under the ice. A listening post. Maybe worse.

BYRD
It isn't Russian.

STILES
Then you won't mind finding out for us.
(to Prescott)
Give him his flight. On three conditions. I go with the expedition. Everything found is classified. And everything found belongs to my office.

Byrd looks at Stiles' outstretched hand for a long beat.

Then he shakes it.

STILES (CONT'D)
Whatever's down there, Admiral, I'd rather we found it first.

EXT. NAVAL AIR STATION PATUXENT RIVER - HANGAR - NIGHT

Rain hammers the tarmac. A lone figure sits in the open mouth of a hangar, feet dangling off a crate, staring at the storm.

LT. COMMANDER FRANK DELANEY (32). Flight jacket. Two days of stubble. A coffee cup gone cold in his hands. The best pilot in the Navy, and the most tired.

Headlights sweep across him. A car door. Byrd walks in out of the rain.

FRANK
Admiral. If you're here to sign my cast, I don't have one.

BYRD
I'm here because you're the best foul-weather pilot in the Navy. And I need a man who can fly where the instruments quit.

FRANK
I don't fly into clouds anymore, sir. Ask anybody. I take the mail run to Norfolk on sunny days.

BYRD
I read your file. You flew a camera plane at Bikini.

Frank's face closes like a fist.

FRANK
They sent us in after the blast. To take pictures of the cloud.
(beat)
Everything went white. Not bright. White. Like the world had been erased. The radio was screaming. I couldn't see my own hands on the stick.
(beat)
I still see it, sir. Every time I close my eyes.

Byrd sits down on the crate beside him. Rain drums the roof.

BYRD
Then come see something that isn't a bomb.

FRANK
Like what?

BYRD
I don't know. That's the point. Something nobody on Earth has ever seen.

FRANK
And if it's just more ice?

BYRD
Then you'll have had a very long, very cold nap.

Despite himself, Frank laughs. One short bark. It surprises him.

He looks at the rain. Then at the old man beside him.

FRANK
When do we leave?

INT. NAVY RADIO LISTENING STATION - MARYLAND - NIGHT

A windowless room hums with receivers. RADIOMEN in headsets scribble in logbooks.

At the end of the row: RADIOMAN SECOND CLASS EDDIE NAVARRO (19). Skinny. Huge headphones. A dog-eared pulp magazine,

ATOMIC ADVENTURE STORIES, tucked under his logbook. On the cover: a rocket ship and a bug-eyed monster.

A CHIEF looms over him, waving a logbook.

CHIEF
Navarro! Forty-one nights you've logged the same noise! Forty-one!

EDDIE
It's not noise, Chief, it repeats every eleven minutes, and it's got a melody, like somebody humming --

CHIEF
The Navy does not pay you to log humming!

BYRD (O.S.)
I'd like to see those logs, Chief.

The Chief turns. Freezes. Salutes so fast he nearly knocks his own hat off.

Byrd stands in the doorway with Evelyn.

Eddie's headphones slide off his head. His mouth opens. Nothing comes out.

EDDIE
You're... you're...

BYRD
I am.

EDDIE
I read "Skyward" three times, sir! And "Alone" four times. Well. Three and a half. The part with the stove scared me.

BYRD
Scared me too.
(nodding at the logs)
Every eleven minutes?

EDDIE
Like clockwork, sir. And here's the crazy part. It's getting louder.

Byrd and Evelyn exchange a look.

BYRD
How'd you like to go somewhere cold, son?

EDDIE
How cold?

EVELYN
The coldest place on Earth.

Eddie grabs his pulp magazine and his headphones.

EDDIE
I'll get my coat.

INT. NAVY DEPARTMENT - BASEMENT STOREROOM - DAY

A cramped room full of mops and filing cabinets. A hand-lettered sign taped to the door: "SPECIAL PROJECTS (TEMPORARY)."

MONTAGE - PLANNING THE EXPEDITION

-- Maps cover every surface. Byrd, Evelyn, Frank and Eddie crowd around a table. Evelyn draws rings around the anomaly in red pencil.

EVELYN
It's here. Roughly. Six hundred miles past the Pole, in the middle of the blank.

FRANK
Roughly.

EVELYN
It moves, Commander.

FRANK
So do I. Usually away from things that move.

-- Eddie proudly unveils a cheap dime-store globe. He has drilled a hole through the top and the bottom.

EDDIE
John Cleves Symmes. Eighteen-eighteen. He said the Earth is hollow, with a big hole at each pole. He even asked Congress for money to sail into one.

EVELYN
And Congress said no.

EDDIE
Congress says no to everything.

Byrd picks up the globe and peers through the hole, one eye closed. He grins. He sets it on his desk, where it stays.

-- EXT. PATUXENT RIVER - AIRFIELD - DAY. A DOUGLAS R4D SKYTRAIN sits on the apron, a big silver twin-engine transport. Mechanics bolt on huge SKIS and extra fuel tanks. Frank walks the wings, running his hand along the metal like a horse trainer.

-- A painter finishes lettering the nose: IGLOO.

EDDIE
Who's Igloo?

BYRD
The best navigator I ever had. Went with me to both poles. Never once got lost.

EDDIE
What happened to him?

BYRD
Old age. He was a fox terrier.

-- EXT. PATUXENT RIVER - TEST RANGE - DAY. Four silver rocket bottles strapped to a test sled. A COUNTDOWN. The bottles ignite with a deafening ROAR. The sled screams down the track in a wall of smoke.

Prescott's AIDE, watching too close, has his hat blown clean off his head. It lands smoking in a puddle.

FRANK
(impressed)
JATO. Jet-assisted takeoff. Strap four of those to the Igloo and you could launch her off a rooftop.

BYRD
Or a carrier deck.

Frank stops smiling.

FRANK
Nobody has ever launched a plane that big off a carrier.

BYRD
Then we'll be first.

-- INT. QUARTERMASTER'S DEPOT - DAY. A QUARTERMASTER holds up a polar parka that would fit a grizzly bear.

QUARTERMASTER
Men's sizes only, miss.

-- LATER. Evelyn sits cross-legged on the depot floor, cutting the giant parka down to her size with surgical scissors. She bites off a thread. Perfect fit.

-- In every scene, if you look closely: STILES. In a doorway. At the back of the hangar. Watching. Writing in a small black notebook.

-- INT. BASEMENT STOREROOM - NIGHT. Byrd, alone, opens an old leather DIARY. The pages are stiff with age. "ADVANCE BASE - 1934."

He turns to the last entry. The unfinished letter: "My dearest Marie. If you are reading this, then..."

The rest of the page is blank.

END MONTAGE.

INT. BYRD HOME - BEDROOM - BOSTON - NIGHT

SUPER: "BOSTON - DECEMBER 1946"

A warm, lamplit room. A battered expedition trunk lies open on the bed.

MARIE BYRD (57), elegant, unflappable, a woman who has waved goodbye from a hundred piers, sits in an armchair with a book she is not reading. She watches her husband pack.

Byrd tucks a small leather DOG COLLAR into the trunk, a brass tag hanging from it: IGLOO.

MARIE
You've packed the collar.

BYRD
It's a long trip.

MARIE
You only pack the collar when it's personal.
(closing the book)
This one isn't for the Navy, is it, Dick?

He sits on the edge of the bed. He has never been able to lie to her. He's never really tried.

BYRD
In thirty-four. At Advance Base. When the stove was killing me.

(beat)
Somebody opened the door, Marie.

She doesn't laugh. She doesn't look surprised.

MARIE
I know.

BYRD
You know?

MARIE
You talked in your sleep for a year after you came home. Every night. You kept saying, "Thank you." Over and over.
(beat)
I always wondered who you were thanking.

BYRD
So did I.

She crosses to him and straightens his collar, the way she has a thousand times.

MARIE
Then go and find out.
(beat)
And Dick. Come home. I am tired of reading about you in the newspapers.

BYRD
I'll come home. And I'll tell you everything. You first. Before any newspaper.

MARIE
Promise?

BYRD
Promise.

EXT. NORFOLK NAVAL BASE - PIER - DAY

A NAVY BAND plays. Flags snap in the wind. The enormous grey hull of the aircraft carrier USS PHILIPPINE SEA towers over the pier. On her flight deck, wings folded under tarps: six R4D transports, the IGLOO among them.

A crowd of REPORTERS in fedoras surrounds Byrd at the foot of the gangway. Newsreel cameras whir. Flashbulbs pop.

REPORTER #1
Admiral! What do you expect to find down there?

BYRD
The unknown, gentlemen. Same as always.

REPORTER #2
Any chance you'll find Santa's workshop?

BYRD
Wrong pole, son.

Big laugh from the press. Byrd beams. He is in his element.

At the top of the gangway, Stiles watches the reporters with open distaste.

Frank, Evelyn and Eddie climb aboard with their sea bags. Eddie waves at the cameras. Nobody is filming him. He waves anyway.

EXT. USS PHILIPPINE SEA - STERN - LATER

The carrier slides out to sea. The Virginia shore shrinks to a grey line.

Byrd stands alone at the rail, looking south. Stiles joins him.

STILES
Penny for your thoughts, Admiral.

BYRD
I was thinking it's an awfully long way to go to find out you were wrong.

STILES
Or right.

BYRD
That's what scares me.

The ship turns south, into open ocean.

FADE OUT.

EXT. USS PHILIPPINE SEA - FLIGHT DECK - DAY

SUPER: "THE EQUATOR - JANUARY 1947"

Blazing tropical sun. Hundreds of SAILORS crowd the flight deck, howling with laughter.

On a throne built from ammunition crates sits KING NEPTUNE: a barrel-chested CHIEF in a mop wig, a seaweed beard and a cardboard crown, brandishing a trident made from a boat hook.

It's the ancient Navy ceremony of CROSSING THE LINE. Sailors who have crossed the equator before -- SHELLBACKS -- are initiating the ones who haven't. The POLLYWOGS.

A line of Pollywogs in their underwear crawls across the deck through a canvas chute full of old spaghetti. Eddie is among them, dripping marinara, laughing too hard to crawl straight.

KING NEPTUNE
Next Pollywog! Approach the Royal Court!

Two burly Shellbacks frog-march STILES forward. He is still wearing his grey suit and tie.

STILES
This is absurd. I'm a civilian. I'm exempt.

BYRD
(from the Royal Court, wearing a paper crown of his own)
Nobody is exempt from King Neptune, Mr. Stiles. Not even the Central Intelligence Group.

KING NEPTUNE
What is the Central Intelligence Group?

STILES
That's classified.

KING NEPTUNE
Dunk him.

SPLASH. Stiles goes backwards into a canvas pool of seawater. He surfaces, sputtering, hair plastered flat, his tie floating beside him like a dead fish.

The deck ROARS.

Off to the side, Frank laughs. A real laugh. He catches himself doing it and stops, surprised.

EVELYN (O.S.)
That's two.

He turns. Evelyn, wearing a sun hat and a paper "Honorary Shellback" sash, sits on a crate beside him.

FRANK
Two what?

EVELYN
Laughs. Since Patuxent. I'm keeping count.

FRANK
Why?

EVELYN
I'm a scientist. I keep count of everything.

INT. USS PHILIPPINE SEA - WARDROOM - NIGHT

Dim red lights. The hum of engines. The crew of the Igloo shares a table loaded with coffee mugs.

Eddie reads ATOMIC ADVENTURE STORIES by flashlight. The cover: "THE HOLLOW WORLD OF ZARKON!"

FRANK
You believe that stuff, kid?

EDDIE
Not the Zarkon part. Zarkon's ridiculous. He has four arms and a monocle.
(beat)
But the hollow part? Why not? Nobody's ever been to the middle of Antarctica. Nobody's ever been to the middle of anything.

EVELYN
The Earth is not hollow, Eddie. We know its mass. If it were hollow it would weigh half as much as it does.

EDDIE
Unless whatever's inside is really heavy.

Evelyn opens her mouth. Closes it. Frowns, actually considering it.

FRANK
Don't encourage him, Doc.

Byrd enters with a fresh pot of coffee and sits.

EDDIE
Admiral. Settle this. What do you think is down there?

Byrd pours, taking his time.

BYRD
In twenty-six, when Floyd Bennett and I flew over the North Pole, the whole world said there was nothing there but ice.
(beat)
And they were right. Nothing but ice.

EDDIE
(deflated)
Oh.

BYRD
But I didn't know that until I went and looked.
(raising his mug)
To going and looking.

They clink mugs. Even Frank.

EXT. SOUTHERN OCEAN - DAY

The carrier ploughs through a grey, heaving sea. And then: the first ICEBERG. A white cathedral the size of a city block, glowing blue at the waterline.

Then another. Then dozens. A whole drifting city of ice.

EXT. USS PHILIPPINE SEA - FLIGHT DECK - DAY

Bitter wind. Sailors in parkas scrape ice off the deck. Byrd stands at the rail in his fur-trimmed parka, breath smoking. Stiles joins him, swaddled in a borrowed coat three sizes too big.

On an ice floe drifting past: a dozen EMPEROR PENGUINS, watching the ship with total contempt.

STILES
I'm told you've done this five times.

BYRD
This is my fourth trip south. Fifth, if you count the time I tried to quit.

STILES
Why do you keep coming back?

BYRD
It's the last place on Earth that doesn't belong to anybody. No flags. No fences. No armies.
(beat)
Not yet.

Stiles takes that in. He looks out at the ice.

STILES
My brother was on the Arizona. At Pearl Harbor.

Byrd turns to him.

STILES (CONT'D)
They say it happened in nine minutes. Eleven hundred men. Because we weren't ready. Because nobody was watching the places nobody watches.
(beat)
I am going to spend the rest of my life watching those places, Admiral. If there is something under that ice -- a weapon, a fuel, anything -- I want it in American hands before Moscow even knows it's there.

BYRD
And if it isn't a weapon?

STILES
Everything is a weapon, Admiral. If you hold it right.

A long silence. The penguins drift past.

BYRD
I'm sorry about your brother.

STILES
So am I.

EXT. USS PHILIPPINE SEA - FLIGHT DECK - DAY

SUPER: "JANUARY 29, 1947"

The flight deck has been cleared. One aircraft sits at the very stern: the IGLOO, enormous on a carrier deck, its wingtips nearly brushing the island superstructure. Four silver JATO bottles are strapped to its belly.

Hundreds of sailors line the catwalks. Nobody has ever seen this before.

INT. IGLOO - COCKPIT - CONTINUOUS

Frank in the left seat. Byrd in the right. Eddie at the radio station behind them. Evelyn strapped into a jump seat, clutching her instruments.

Frank's hands are white on the yoke. Sweat on his lip, despite the cold.

FRANK
Three hundred feet of deck. She needs about a thousand.

BYRD
That's what the rockets are for.

FRANK
And if the rockets don't fire?

BYRD
Then we'll go for a swim.
(beat)
Frank. You can do this.

FRANK
You don't know that.

BYRD
No. But I'd bet the Navy's plane on it.

Frank looks at him. Takes a breath. Shoves the throttles forward.

EXT. USS PHILIPPINE SEA - FLIGHT DECK - CONTINUOUS

The engines thunder. A FLIGHT DECK OFFICER drops his flag.

The Igloo lumbers forward. Too slow. Way too slow. The bow rushes toward it --

FRANK (O.S.)
JATO! Now!

The rocket bottles IGNITE. Four tongues of white fire. A wall of smoke engulfs the deck. The Igloo leaps forward like a kicked horse --

-- shoots off the bow --

-- and DROPS. Out of sight. Down toward the black water.

The sailors on the catwalks lean out, horrified.

A long, terrible beat.

Then the Igloo CLAWS back up into view, engines screaming, climbing, climbing, banking into the grey sky.

The deck ERUPTS in cheers. Hats fly into the air.

INT. IGLOO - COCKPIT - CONTINUOUS

Eddie is screaming. Evelyn is laughing. Frank is shaking.

And Byrd is grinning like a ten-year-old on a roller coaster.

BYRD
Hot dog! HOT DOG!

FRANK
(through clenched teeth)
Don't. Ever. Make me do that again.

BYRD
First time in history, Frank! First!

EXT. LITTLE AMERICA IV - DAY

SUPER: "LITTLE AMERICA IV - ROSS ICE SHELF, ANTARCTICA"

A town of tents and Quonset huts on a plain of ice that goes on forever. Tractors. Radio masts. Sled dogs. A runway of packed snow marked with black flags.

The Igloo touches down on its skis in a spray of powder.

EXT. LITTLE AMERICA IV - RUNWAY - CONTINUOUS

The crew climbs out into the brutal cold. Their breath freezes on their scarves.

Stiles, who flew in on an earlier plane, waits for them beside a brand-new hut bristling with antennas. Inside, two RADIOMEN hunch over a strange machine: a RADIO DIRECTION FINDER, a looped antenna that turns on a dial.

BYRD
What's that?

STILES
Insurance.

EDDIE
(low, to Byrd)
That's a direction finder, sir. You use two of 'em to triangulate a radio signal. Tells you exactly where it's coming from.

BYRD
Where's the other one?

STILES
On the flagship. You'll report in every hour, on the hour. Just so we know you're safe.

Byrd and Stiles hold each other's gaze.

BYRD
Every hour, on the hour.

INT. LITTLE AMERICA IV - SCIENCE HUT - DAY

Evelyn's instruments fill the tiny hut. A magnetometer needle twitches. Her wire recorder plays the HUM through a speaker: louder now. Clearer.

She checks a chart. Checks it again.

EVELYN
It's moved closer. Eighty miles since November.
(beat)
It's as if it knows we're here.

FRANK
(in the doorway)
Great. Love that. That's very comforting.

A RADIO ANNOUNCER crackles from a shelf radio:

RADIO ANNOUNCER (V.O.)
...and in other news from Operation Highjump, Navy fliers report finding ice-free hills and open lakes on the Antarctic coast. Newsmen are already calling it a Shangri-La...

Eddie looks at Byrd, eyes shining.

EDDIE
See? It's started.

BYRD
What's started?

EDDIE
The weird stuff, sir.

EXT. LITTLE AMERICA IV - "NIGHT"

It is midnight. The sun hangs just above the horizon, casting long orange shadows across the camp. It does not set.

INT. LITTLE AMERICA IV - BYRD'S HUT - CONTINUOUS

Byrd writes by the light of the midnight sun.

BYRD (V.O.)
February 18th, 1947. The sun has not set here since October. It circles the sky like a dog that cannot settle.

INT. LITTLE AMERICA IV - BUNK HUT - CONTINUOUS

Frank lies awake in his bunk, eyes wide open. Every time they start to close, he forces them open again.

BYRD (V.O.)
Delaney does not sleep. I hear him walking the camp at all hours.

Across the hut, Eddie writes a letter by flashlight.

INSERT - THE LETTER

"Dear Mama. Don't worry. The Admiral says it's just a weather flight."

He crosses out "weather." Writes "VERY IMPORTANT."

BYRD (V.O.)
Navarro writes to his mother every day. He has nowhere to mail the letters.

INT. LITTLE AMERICA IV - SCIENCE HUT - CONTINUOUS

Evelyn, asleep at her desk, head on her charts, pencil still in her hand.

BYRD (V.O.)
And Dr. March has not left her instruments in three days.

INT. LITTLE AMERICA IV - BYRD'S HUT - CONTINUOUS

Byrd sets down his pen. He takes out Igloo's collar and turns the brass tag over in his fingers.

BYRD (V.O.)
Tomorrow we fly into the blank. I have told the Navy it is a survey flight. I have told my crew it is a survey flight.
(beat)
I have not told anyone that I am going back to thank somebody.

EXT. LITTLE AMERICA IV - RUNWAY - DAY

SUPER: "FEBRUARY 19, 1947"

The Igloo's engines cough and roar to life. Snow blasts out behind the propellers.

Stiles stands in the door of his radio hut, holding his hat against the wind.

STILES
Every hour, Admiral!

BYRD
(from the cockpit window)
On the hour, Mr. Stiles!

The Igloo surges down the runway and lifts into the hard blue sky.

INT. RADIO HUT - CONTINUOUS

Stiles leans over his radiomen.

STILES
Keep a bearing on that plane every second it's in the air. Every second.

INT. IGLOO - COCKPIT - DAY

Below: white. Above: blue. Nothing else. The most empty place on Earth.

BYRD (V.O.)
Flight log. Hour one. Visibility unlimited. Nothing in any direction but ice.

-- Eddie taps out an hourly report on his Morse key.

EDDIE
(into his headset)
Little America, Igloo. All normal. Over.

BYRD (V.O.)
Hour three. We crossed the Pole at eleven-forty. I have now flown over both ends of the Earth more times than any man alive. It never gets less lonely.

-- Evelyn watches her magnetometer. The needle creeps upward.

BYRD (V.O.)
Hour five.

-- The magnetometer needle jumps. Swings. Jumps again.

EVELYN
It's getting stronger. Much stronger.

-- The plane's MAGNETIC COMPASS begins to drift. Then swing. Then spin in slow, lazy circles.

FRANK
Compass is gone.

-- Through the static in Eddie's headset: the HUM. Rising. Falling. Like breathing.

EDDIE
Sir. You hear that?

BYRD
I hear it.

Frank taps the fuel gauge.

FRANK
Admiral. We're at the point of no return. If we don't turn around in ten minutes, we won't have the fuel to get back.

BYRD
Then we have ten minutes.

FRANK
To do what?

Evelyn points through the windshield. Her voice is very small.

EVELYN
To decide about that.

EXT. ANTARCTIC PLATEAU - CONTINUOUS

Ahead, stretching from one edge of the horizon to the other, rising from the ice to the very top of the sky:

THE VEIL.

A colossal curtain of light. Green and violet, shimmering and folding like silk in a wind, even in broad daylight. At its base, black storm clouds churn against the ice. Lightning crawls through it in slow, silent veins.

INT. IGLOO - COCKPIT - CONTINUOUS

Nobody speaks.

EDDIE
That's... that's an aurora. Isn't it? Doc?

EVELYN
Auroras don't touch the ground, Eddie.

FRANK
That's not weather.

BYRD
No. It isn't.
(beat)
Fly into it.

Frank's hands freeze on the yoke.

The light from the Veil floods the cockpit, brighter, whiter, and --

FLASH CUT TO:

EXT. BIKINI ATOLL - SKY - DAY (FLASHBACK)

Through a cockpit window: a colossal MUSHROOM CLOUD boiling into the sky. Then WHITE. Everything, white.

BACK TO SCENE

INT. IGLOO - COCKPIT - CONTINUOUS

Frank is hyperventilating.

FRANK
I can't. I can't, sir. I can't fly into that.

Byrd puts a hand on his arm.

BYRD
Frank. Look at me.

Frank tears his eyes from the Veil.

BYRD (CONT'D)
That is not what you saw at Bikini. Whatever's on the other side of that light, it didn't kill anybody.

FRANK
How do you know that?

BYRD
Because it saved my life once.

A long beat. The Veil fills the windshield.

FRANK
If I die, I'm going to be very annoyed with you.

BYRD
That's fair.

Frank pushes the throttles forward.

EXT. THE VEIL - CONTINUOUS

The tiny silver plane flies into the curtain of light and vanishes.

INT. IGLOO - COCKPIT - CONTINUOUS

CHAOS. The plane bucks like a wild animal. The windows go white. Ice crackles across the windshield.

Ghostly blue flames dance along the wings: ST. ELMO'S FIRE.

Every needle on the instrument panel spins at once. Then they all drop dead to zero.

EDDIE
Radio's gone! Everything's gone!

The engines cough. Sputter. Catch. Cough again.

Evelyn grips her seat, eyes squeezed shut.

Frank fights the yoke, teeth bared.

And then --

Silence.

The engines are still turning. We can see the propellers. But the sound is gone, as if someone pressed a pillow over the world.

White. Nothing but white. Floating.

A long, long beat.

EDDIE
(whispering)
Are we dead?

EVELYN
If we were dead, my feet wouldn't be this cold.

Slowly, the white begins to thin.

EXT. THE THROAT - CONTINUOUS

The Igloo drifts out of the white.

Below it, the ice falls away into a COLOSSAL FUNNEL. A canyon a hundred miles across, spiraling down and down into the Earth like water down a drain. Its walls are ice at the top, then blue rock, then black rock veined with glowing minerals.

The plane follows the spiral down.

INT. IGLOO - COCKPIT - CONTINUOUS

Sound returns all at once: the engines, roaring. Everyone gasps like swimmers surfacing.

FRANK
Altimeter's working. I'm getting -- this can't be right. We're below sea level. Two thousand feet below. Five thousand.

EVELYN
Temperature's rising.

INSERT - THE OUTSIDE AIR THERMOMETER

The needle climbs. Minus forty. Minus twenty. Zero. Thirty-two. Fifty.

BACK TO SCENE

A loud CRACK. Everyone jumps. A sheet of ice the size of a door peels off the wing and tumbles away.

Then another. And another. The Igloo is shedding its ice like an old skin.

The canyon walls below are changing: from black rock to moss. To grass. To FORESTS of enormous ferns.

Frank pulls off one glove. Then the other. He stares at his bare hands.

Evelyn slides open the little side window. WARM AIR rushes in. It smells like rain and flowers.

EVELYN
Seventy degrees. It's seventy degrees.

Byrd takes off his fur hat. His hair blows in the warm wind.

EXT. THE HIDDEN REALM - SKY - CONTINUOUS

The Igloo bursts out of the bottom of the Throat into OPEN SKY --

-- and we see THE HIDDEN REALM for the first time.

A vast world, lit gold. Forests, rivers, mountains, lakes. But the horizon is WRONG. It does not fall away. It curves UP. Up and up on every side, rising into the haze like the inside of a great bowl, until high overhead, faint as a dream, there are more continents. More seas. Hanging upside down.

And in the very center of the sky, where no sun should be, hangs a SUN. Small. Golden. Steady. It pulses slowly, like a heartbeat.

INT. IGLOO - COCKPIT - CONTINUOUS

Total silence.

EDDIE
Holy... mackerel.

EVELYN
(barely breathing)
The horizon curves up. It curves up. We're inside. We're INSIDE.

Byrd stares. His eyes are wet.

BYRD
Gentlemen. Doctor.
(beat)
We are off the map.

EXT. THE HIDDEN REALM - MEADOWS - DAY

The Igloo flies low over a vast golden grassland. A herd of shaggy shapes lumbers through the grass -- they look up at the plane.

WOOLLY MAMMOTHS. Twenty of them. Tusks curling like ivory question marks.

INT. IGLOO - COCKPIT - CONTINUOUS

Eddie has his face pressed against the window.

EDDIE
Those are mammoths. Those are MAMMOTHS!

Byrd grabs a camera from his flight bag and starts SHOOTING through the window. Click. Wind. Click.

BYRD
Proof, Doctor. Nobody believed Columbus either.

EVELYN
Plenty of people believed Columbus. He was just wrong about where he was.

BYRD
(clicking away)
I know exactly where I am. I'm in the history books.

EXT. THE HIDDEN REALM - RIVER VALLEY - DAY

A wide, glittering river. And over it, a RIVER OF BIRDS: a flock so enormous it darkens the sky, millions of grey-blue birds with long tails and rose-colored breasts, flowing like smoke.

The Igloo flies alongside the flock. The birds part around the wings.

INT. IGLOO - COCKPIT - CONTINUOUS

Byrd lowers the camera. He's not taking pictures now. He's just watching.

BYRD
Passenger pigeons.

EVELYN
That's impossible. They're extinct. The last one died in a zoo in Cincinnati in 1914. Her name was Martha.

BYRD
My grandfather used to tell me about them. Said a flock could blot out the sun over the Shenandoah Valley for three whole days.
(beat)
I always thought he was exaggerating.

EDDIE
Nobody told the pigeons they're extinct, Doc.

Eddie fumbles with his radio. Static. He twists dials. Static with something underneath.

EDDIE (CONT'D)
(into the headset)
Little America, Little America, this is Igloo! Do you read? You are not gonna believe this --

INT. LITTLE AMERICA IV - RADIO HUT - SAME

Stiles and his two radiomen huddle over the receiver. Through a blizzard of static, fragments:

EDDIE (V.O.)
(broken)
...green... seventy degr...
MAMMOTHS... a sun... there's a sun...

The direction-finding antenna swings back and forth.

RADIOMAN #1
Signal's bouncing all over the place, sir. I can't get a clean bearing.

Stiles stares at the receiver. Very quietly:

STILES
Then get me two.

INT. IGLOO - COCKPIT - DAY

Frank leans forward, squinting at something off the wing.

FRANK
We've got company.

EXT. THE HIDDEN REALM - SKY - CONTINUOUS

Three CRAFT rise silently alongside the Igloo.

They are nothing like airplanes. Each is shaped like a great seed, pearl-white and smooth, rimmed with bands of rippling light. No engines. No wings. No sound. They glide as easily as thoughts.

INT. IGLOO - COCKPIT - CONTINUOUS

Frank banks hard left. The craft follow without effort. He dives. They're already there. He pulls up. They're waiting.

FRANK
I can't shake them.

BYRD
Don't try. If they wanted to hurt us, they'd have done it.

The radio CRACKLES. The hum swells, and then resolves into a VOICE. Warm. Musical. Speaking perfect English, with the careful, round vowels of a 1930s radio announcer.

VOICE (V.O.)
Good afternoon, Admiral Byrd. Welcome. Please don't be alarmed. We'll take it from here.

The yoke goes slack in Frank's hands. The engines throttle back on their own to a gentle purr. A soft golden light wraps around the plane.

FRANK
(hands raised off the yoke)
I'm not flying this plane anymore.

Byrd grabs the radio microphone.

BYRD
This is Byrd. Who am I speaking to?

VOICE (V.O.)
A friend. Please, stay tuned.

The radio goes quiet. Beat.

EDDIE
Did it just say "stay tuned"?

EXT. SOLACE - LANDING TERRACE - DAY

The Igloo settles gently onto a vast terrace of polished crystal, carried by the three seed-craft like a leaf on water. Its skis touch down without a sound.

Below the terrace, filling a valley ringed by waterfalls, is a CITY.

SOLACE.

It was not built. It was grown. Towers of pale crystal and living stone spiral upward like seashells, wrapped in hanging gardens. Bridges of pure light arc between them. Waterfalls pour off the cliffs -- and halfway down, the water breaks into mist that drifts slowly UPWARD, glittering. The whole city glows faintly, as if lit from inside.

The cockpit door opens. The crew of the Igloo climbs out, one by one, slowly, onto the crystal.

They stand in a line. Warm wind. Birdsong. The faint sound of chimes.

EDDIE
(whispering)
What do we do?

BYRD
(whispering)
Smile. Don't make any sudden moves.

FRANK
(whispering)
Is that what you did with the penguins?

BYRD
The penguins didn't like me either.

At the far end of the terrace, a doorway of light opens in a crystal wall.

And THE ILUN step out.

There are a dozen of them. They are TALL -- seven feet -- and slender, and they move like dancers. Their skin is pale and pearly, like moonstone, and beneath it run delicate lines of LIGHT that ripple and shift color as they move: soft blue, pale gold, violet. Their eyes are large and dark, and deep inside them glitter tiny points of light, like a night sky.

They stop at a respectful distance. Silence.

The Ilun watch the humans. The humans watch the Ilun.

Evelyn's hand finds Frank's arm. He doesn't shake it off.

Finally, Eddie steps forward. His voice cracks.

EDDIE
H-hello. We come in peace.
(beat)
Gum?

He holds out a stick of chewing gum.

The tallest ILUN GUARD regards the gum. Steps forward. Takes it delicately with long fingers. Sniffs it. Then, in a deep, rich, perfect radio announcer's voice:

ILUN GUARD
And now... a word from our sponsor.

Eddie looks back at Byrd, baffled. Byrd shrugs.

Suddenly, a small figure DARTS out from behind the guards.

WREN. A young Ilun, half the height of the others, with enormous dark eyes. Her light patterns are brighter than the adults', flickering and bursting in gold and pink like a firework show she cannot control.

She zooms right up to the humans. Circles Frank. Pokes his leather flight jacket. Sniffs Evelyn's hair. Peers into Byrd's face from about two inches away.

Then she plucks Eddie's HARMONICA out of his shirt pocket, blows into it -- a horrible SQUAWK -- and bursts into delighted, chiming laughter.

A deep, discordant CHORD rings out across the terrace like a slammed door.

WARDEN CASSOR strides through the guards. Tall even for an Ilun, armored in plates of dark crystal. His light patterns burn a steady, wary RED-ORANGE.

Wren freezes. Her lights dim to a guilty pink. She hands the harmonica back to Eddie and retreats -- but only about three steps.

CASSOR
(to the humans, cold)
You will come.

INT. SOLACE - HALL OF THE ELDER - DAY

A vast domed chamber. Through a crystal opening at its peak, the light of the inner sun pours down in a golden column.

Cassor marches the crew across the floor. Ilun line the walls, their lights flickering with curiosity. Wren trails behind at a distance, trying very hard to look like she's supposed to be there.

At the center of the light stands ELDER IRITH.

She is ancient -- you can feel it -- and taller than all the others, robed in fabric that seems woven from light and water. Her skin patterns are a soft, slow silver, like frost forming on glass.

She approaches Byrd. Studies his face for a long time.

IRITH
You have grown old, Richard.

BYRD
I'm sorry?

IRITH
When last we met, you were very cold. And very alone.
(beat)
You were writing a letter to your wife. A letter you believed she would read after you were gone.

Byrd can't breathe.

BYRD
The light at the door.
(beat)
It was you.

IRITH
Your little fire was stealing your breath. So I opened your door.

BYRD
Why? Why would you --

IRITH
Because you were writing to someone you loved.
(beat)
We could not let that letter be your last.

Byrd's eyes fill. He tries to speak. Can't. Finally:

BYRD
Thank you.

(beat)
I've been waiting thirteen years to say that.

IRITH
I know. You said it many times in your sleep. We listen to many things.

Byrd laughs, wiping his eyes.

Evelyn steps forward, unable to stop herself.

EVELYN
Forgive me. Elder. Where are we? Who are you?

IRITH
You are in the place we call Solace. And we are the Ilun.
(beat)
We came here from a world very far away. A long, long time ago.

EDDIE
(to himself)
Aliens. I knew it. Zarkon, eat your heart out.

BYRD
Why did you bring us here? Why now?

Irith's silver light dims. She turns and looks up at the column of golden light.

IRITH
Because your people have learned to make suns.

Silence falls over the chamber.

IRITH (CONT'D)
Once in a desert. Twice over cities. Twice upon the sea.
(beat)
We felt every one, here, in the heart of the world. Like stones dropped into still water.

Frank goes very still.

CASSOR
And they will make more. Hundreds more. Thousands.

IRITH
My people are divided, Admiral. Some of us wish to hide forever, deeper than you could ever follow. Some of us wish to...
(a glance at Cassor)
...act.

BYRD
Act how?

Irith doesn't answer that.

IRITH
Before we decide what to do about your kind, I wished to know one of you again.

BYRD
You want to find out if we're worth the trouble.

IRITH
Yes.

A small voice from the back of the hall:

WREN
I already like them.

CASSOR
(not turning around)
No one asked you.

IRITH
(a faint smile)
Then it is decided. The little one will be your guide while you are among us.

CASSOR
Elder. She is a child.

IRITH
So are they, Warden.
(beat)
And you will go with them.

Cassor's red light flares. But he bows.

Wren's lights explode into gold.

EXT. SOLACE - BRIDGE OF LIGHT - DAY

A bridge made of nothing but solid, shimmering light arcs between two crystal towers. Far, far below: the city, the waterfalls, the drifting mist.

Wren skips across it backwards, facing the humans.

Eddie follows, delighted, peering down through his own feet.

Frank inches along behind him, eyes fixed straight ahead, refusing to look down.

FRANK
Is it supposed to be see-through?

WREN
Is what supposed to be what?

FRANK
Never mind.

Cassor walks at the rear, silent, a red shadow.

Byrd catches up to Wren.

BYRD
I'm Richard. That's Frank, Evelyn, and Eddie. What's your name?

Wren stops. She opens her mouth, and out comes a sound like three bells struck at once, while a ripple of colored light runs from her forehead to her fingertips. It is beautiful.

Eddie tries to repeat it. He produces something like a goose stepping on a harmonica.

Wren giggles so hard her lights go pink.

BYRD (CONT'D)
I'm afraid we can't say that. Mind if we call you something else?

WREN
What?

BYRD
How about Wren?

WREN
What is a Wren?

BYRD
A bird. The littlest bird in Virginia, with the biggest song you ever heard.

WREN
A BIRD! Like the Kept ones! The ones who go UP!
(beat, suspicious)
And what is a "Byrd"?

BYRD
Same thing, more or less.

Wren's lights BURST into gold.

WREN
You are a bird too! We are both birds!

She spins in a circle on the bridge. Frank grabs the railing that doesn't exist.

EVELYN
Wren. How do you speak English so well?

WREN
We learned your words from the singing air.

EDDIE
The singing --
(it hits him)
The RADIO. You listen to the radio!

WREN
Always! For years and years. The Elder learned from the man who reads the news every evening. The guards learned from the voices that sell soap.
(proudly)
I learned from the baseball.

EDDIE
You like baseball?

WREN
I do not know what it is. But the man who talks about it gets SO happy.
(imitating perfectly)
"And it's a long fly ball to deep center... it is... GONE!"

Eddie clutches his heart.

EDDIE
I think I'm in love with this place.

Evelyn glances back at Cassor, walking stiffly behind them.

EVELYN
And the Warden? Where did he learn?

Wren's lights dim. She lowers her voice.

WREN
From the war. He listened to all of it. Every bomb. Every siren. Every speech.
(beat)
That is why he is so sad.

Cassor's eyes meet Evelyn's. He has heard every word. He looks away.

EXT. THE GARDEN OF THE LOST - DAY

The crew crests a hill and stops dead.

Below them stretches a garden the size of a country: rolling meadows, forests, lakes and marshes, all bathed in golden light, all teeming with life.

WREN
This is where we keep the Kept.

EVELYN
The what?

WREN
The ones your world dropped.

EXT. THE GARDEN OF THE LOST - MEADOW - CONTINUOUS

They walk through waist-high grass.

A dog-like animal with tiger stripes across its back pads out of the bushes and studies them with calm yellow eyes.

EVELYN
That's a thylacine. A Tasmanian tiger. The last one died in a zoo in Hobart. Ten years ago. Ten years!

Byrd raises his camera. Click.

-- A flock of fat, grey, ridiculous-looking birds waddles past Eddie's boots, honking.

EVELYN (CONT'D)
Dodos. They've been gone for nearly three hundred years.

-- On the shore of a lake: a colony of tall black-and-white birds that look like penguins wearing tuxedos two sizes too big.

EVELYN (CONT'D)
Great auks. Gone since 1844.

-- In the shallows of the lake, something enormous rolls lazily in the water: a huge, gentle, whiskered creature, thirty feet long, munching on kelp.

EVELYN (CONT'D)
(voice breaking)
A Steller's sea cow. Nobody has seen one of those since seventeen-sixty-something.

-- At the edge of the forest, a GIANT GROUND SLOTH the size of an elephant rears up on its hind legs and casually strips the leaves from a treetop.

Click. Click. Click. Byrd can't shoot fast enough.

Evelyn sits down in the grass. Just sits. Tears streaming down her face.

Frank kneels beside her, awkward, unsure what to do. He offers her his handkerchief. She takes it.

EVELYN (CONT'D)
I'm sorry. I'm a scientist. I'm supposed to be objective.

FRANK
Doc. I think there's a giant sloth eating a tree over there. I think we can all get a little emotional.

Evelyn laughs through her tears.

Byrd lowers his camera and turns to Wren.

BYRD
Why? Why save them?

WREN
Your world drops things. We pick them up.
(beat)
Because nobody picked us up.

Before Byrd can ask what she means, a DODO waddles up to Eddie, snatches the pack of chewing gum from his shirt pocket with its hooked beak, and swallows it whole. Wrapper and all.

EDDIE
Hey! That was my last pack!

WREN
He's the last too.

Eddie looks at the dodo. The dodo looks at Eddie. Burps.

EDDIE
...Fair enough.

The thylacine wanders over to Frank and sniffs his hand. Then licks it. Frank, very slowly, scratches it behind the ears.

Cassor watches this from a distance, his red light steady.

CASSOR
And your kind would hunt them all again. Within a year.

Nobody has an answer to that.

EXT. SOLACE - SKY DOCK - DAY

Wren leads them aboard a SKIFF: a small Ilun craft shaped like a curled glass leaf. It lifts off silently and rises, up and up, toward the inner sun.

The city shrinks beneath them. The land curves up on every side.

WREN
Hold on to something. Soon you will not be heavy anymore.

FRANK
What does that mean?

EVELYN
(eyes widening)
Oh. Oh! Of course! Newton's shell theorem!

EDDIE
English, Doc!

EVELYN
Inside a hollow sphere, gravity pulls equally in every direction. So it cancels out! It cancels out to nothing!

EDDIE
I said ENGLISH, Doc!

Evelyn's feet lift off the floor of the skiff.

EVELYN
We can FLY.

EXT. THE DRIFT - CONTINUOUS

The skiff floats into a region of sky where the air glitters.

Huge spheres of water hang in the air like glass balloons -- rain that never falls. Seeds the size of umbrellas drift past like dandelion fluff. A flock of passenger pigeons swirls through it all in great looping rivers.

Wren kicks off the edge of the skiff and SOARS out into the open air like a swimmer diving into a pool.

WREN
Come on!

Eddie doesn't hesitate. He leaps -- and FLOATS, arms windmilling, laughing like a maniac.

EDDIE
Wahoooo!

Evelyn pushes off gently and glides, arms spread wide, her hair floating around her face.

Frank grips the skiff's edge, white-knuckled.

BYRD
After you, Commander.

FRANK
Sir, with respect, I've been falling out of the sky my whole life. I'd like to stay in the boat.

Wren swoops past, grabs Frank's hand, and YANKS him out of the skiff.

FRANK (CONT'D)
WHOA --

He tumbles head over heels into the open air. Spinning. Flailing.

And then he stops flailing. He's floating. Upside down. Drifting slowly past a hanging ball of water the size of a car.

He pokes it. It wobbles.

And Frank Delaney begins to LAUGH. A real laugh. A helpless, breathless, tears-in-the-eyes laugh that comes up from somewhere he'd forgotten he had.

Evelyn floats past him, holding up three fingers.

EVELYN
That's three.

Byrd pushes off from the skiff and drifts out on his back, arms open wide, looking straight up at the impossible upside-down continents overhead.

Wren floats up beside him. Upside down, relative to him.

WREN
Is this what your sky is like? Up there?

BYRD
No. Our sky is...
(searching)
Darker. And bigger. And at night, it's full of lights.

WREN
Lights?

BYRD
Stars.

Wren's face is blank. Byrd turns his head toward her.

BYRD (CONT'D)
You don't have stars.

WREN
The old ones remember stars. They sing about them sometimes. But our sun never goes away. There is no... "night."
(beat)
I have never seen a star.

Byrd looks at her, stricken.

He opens his mouth to describe them --

CASSOR (O.S.)
The Elder wishes you to see the Echoes.

Cassor floats at the edge of the Drift, arms folded, perfectly still, like a statue someone forgot to put down.

INT. THE HALL OF ECHOES - DAY

A circular chamber carved from smoky crystal. In its center, a POOL of liquid light, shimmering silver.

Elder Irith waits beside it. The crew gathers around. Wren sits at the edge, unusually quiet.

IRITH
You asked where we came from. I will show you.

She dips her long fingers into the pool.

The light RISES out of it, swirling up around them, filling the chamber, until the walls vanish and they are standing --

EXT. ILUN HOMEWORLD - DAY (ECHO)

-- on a hilltop on another world.

A violet sky with two moons. Seas of deep blue. Cities that rise like coral reefs, glowing with song. Ilun by the millions, their lights shimmering like fields of flowers.

The crew turns in slow circles, stunned. The images are translucent, ghostly -- memories made of light.

IRITH (V.O.)
This was our home. We were many, and we were clever, and we were proud.

The images shift. The cities split into two halves, their lights changing from gold to red. Ilun facing Ilun across a divide.

IRITH (V.O.) (CONT'D)
And we learned to make suns.

In the sky above one of the cities, a point of white light blooms --

-- and grows --

-- and becomes a towering, boiling, terrible PILLAR OF FIRE, mushrooming into the violet sky.

INT. THE HALL OF ECHOES - CONTINUOUS

Frank STAGGERS backward. Out of the light. He crashes into the crystal wall.

FLASH CUT TO:

EXT. BIKINI ATOLL - SKY - DAY (FLASHBACK)

The MUSHROOM CLOUD through the cockpit glass. The WHITE swallowing everything. A radio, screaming.

BACK TO SCENE

INT. THE HALL OF ECHOES - CONTINUOUS

Frank slides down the wall to the floor, gasping, hands over his eyes.

FRANK
Turn it off. Turn it off. Please.

Irith withdraws her hand from the pool. The images collapse back into the silver light. The chamber is quiet.

Evelyn kneels beside Frank. Byrd too.

Irith crosses the chamber and lowers herself to the floor in front of Frank, slowly, the way the very old do. Her silver light softens to a deep, calm blue.

IRITH
You have seen it.

FRANK
(barely audible)
I flew through it. At Bikini. They sent us in to take pictures of the cloud.
(beat)
Everything went white. I couldn't see my own hands. And the whole time I was thinking... we made this. People like me made this.
(beat)
I see it every time I close my eyes. Every single time.

IRITH
May I?

She raises one long hand. Frank hesitates. Then nods.

She lays her palm flat against his chest, over his heart. Her blue light flows down her arm and into him, gentle as water.

Frank's breathing slows. His shoulders loosen. His eyes close.

And this time, he lets them stay closed.

IRITH (CONT'D)
I cannot take the memory from you. And I would not.
(beat)
The ones who remember the fire are the ones who will keep it from burning again.

A tear rolls down Frank's cheek. He nods.

Byrd turns to Irith.

BYRD
That's what happened to your world. A war.

IRITH
A war that ended our world. Our oceans boiled. Our sky burned. Our ground cracked open.
(beat)
A few thousand of us escaped in a ship shaped like a seed. We carried with us one ember from our dying sun, so that we would never forget its light.

She looks up. Through the crystal ceiling, the golden inner sun pulses.

EVELYN
(understanding)
That's not a sun. That's your ember.

IRITH
We wandered for an age. And then we found a young blue world, covered in ice, with a hollow heart. We hid inside it.
(beat)
And we made a vow. We would never again hold the fire. We would watch. We would keep. We would not interfere.

CASSOR
(from the doorway)
And now we watch your kind learn the same lesson we did. The hard way.

BYRD
You had a war that ended your world.

IRITH
And you, Admiral, are having a war that has only just learned how.

CASSOR
Which is why they cannot be trusted.

IRITH
(rising)
Which is why they must be.

EXT. SOLACE - THE GREAT TERRACE - "NIGHT"

There is no night here. But the Ilun have dimmed their city's glow to a soft amber, and hundreds of them have gathered on a vast terrace for a FEAST OF WELCOME.

Ilun MUSIC fills the air: not instruments, but voices, humming in chords, while their light patterns ripple across the crowd in waves, so the music can be SEEN as well as heard.

-- Byrd breaks a chocolate ration bar into pieces and hands them out to a cluster of ILUN CHILDREN. One tastes it. Her lights go through every color of the rainbow in two seconds. The others mob Byrd for more.

-- Frank, sleeves rolled up, teaches a group of young Ilun to throw Eddie's lucky BASEBALL. They throw like they've never thrown anything in their lives. Because they haven't.

WREN
(catching it, ecstatic)
It's a long fly ball! It is GONE!

-- Evelyn sits with three Ilun SCHOLARS, scribbling equations in her notebook while they draw glowing diagrams in the air with their fingertips. She's in heaven.

Eddie sits on the edge of the terrace and pulls out his harmonica. He looks at it. Then at the crowd.

He starts to play. A slow, old, aching tune. "SHENANDOAH."

The Ilun music falters. Stops. The terrace goes quiet. Hundreds of faces turn toward the skinny kid with the harmonica.

Eddie freezes, mid-note, terrified he's committed some terrible offense.

Then one Ilun begins to HUM. Picking up the melody. Then another, adding a harmony. Then a dozen. Then hundreds.

Their light patterns pulse with the music, gold and blue, until the whole terrace is glowing in time with an old American folk song.

Eddie keeps playing, eyes wide, tears streaming.

Byrd, standing at the edge of the crowd, begins to sing softly:

BYRD
Oh Shenandoah, I long to see you...
Away, you rolling river...

Frank and Evelyn stand side by side, listening. Her hand finds his. Neither of them says anything about it.

Across the terrace, Cassor stands alone in the shadows, arms folded. But his light, for just a moment, flickers from red to gold.

He notices. He turns away.

EXT. SOLACE - TERRACE EDGE - LATER

The music has moved on. Byrd sits at the very edge of the terrace, legs dangling over a drop of thousands of feet, looking out at the impossible upward-curving world.

Wren sits down beside him, swinging her legs just like he does.

WREN
Tell me about stars.

Byrd thinks.

BYRD
When the sun goes down at home, the sky turns blue. Then purple. Then black as ink.
(beat)
And then, one by one, little lights come out. Just a few at first. Then hundreds. Then thousands, so many you can't count them.
(beat)
Sailors steer their ships by them. Children make wishes on them. And down here, in the winter, there's a light that dances across the whole sky. Green and red. Like curtains blowing in the wind.

WREN
Like the Veil.

BYRD
A lot like the Veil.

WREN
I want to see them. Just once.

BYRD
Maybe you will.

WREN
The Warden says we can never go up. He says up is where the fire is.

Byrd has no answer.

Wren studies his face intently.

WREN (CONT'D)
Bird. Your face does not glow.

BYRD
No. I'm afraid not.

WREN
When we speak, our light shows what we really feel. Nobody can hide it. Nobody can lie.
(beat)
But your face stays the same color all the time. So how do your people know when somebody means what they say?

BYRD
We don't. Not really.
(beat)
We just decide to trust each other.

Wren thinks about that for a long time.

WREN
That is very brave.

BYRD
Or very foolish. Usually it's both.

EXT. SOLACE - LANDING TERRACE - "NIGHT"

The Igloo sits alone on the crystal terrace, its silver skin glowing amber in the city's dimmed light.

A shadow creeps across the terrace toward it. Eddie. He clambers into the plane.

INT. IGLOO - RADIO STATION - CONTINUOUS

Eddie flips switches. The radio warms up with a hum. He strings the trailing antenna wire out the hatch, aiming it up toward the Throat.

EDDIE
(to himself)
Every hour on the hour. I promised.

He puts on his headphones. Keys the mike.

EDDIE (CONT'D)
Little America, Little America, this is Igloo. Do you read?

INT. LITTLE AMERICA IV - RADIO HUT - SAME

The radio CRACKLES to life, LOUD and CLEAR. Stiles, asleep on a cot, bolts upright.

EDDIE (V.O.)
...Do you read me, Little America?

Stiles lunges for the microphone.

STILES
Igloo, this is Stiles. We read you. Go ahead.

INT. IGLOO - RADIO STATION - INTERCUT

Eddie is bursting with excitement. The words tumble out.

EDDIE
Mr. Stiles! Sir! We're all okay! We're more than okay! You won't believe it! There's a whole world down here, inside the Earth -- there's a city, a real city, made out of crystal -- and they've got mammoths, sir, and dodos --

STILES
Slow down, son. Who's "they"?

EDDIE
The Ilun! They're from another planet! They've been living down here for thousands of years! And they've got this sun, sir -- this little sun right in the middle of everything -- it powers the whole place. The Doc says there's more energy in it than every power plant on Earth put together. Maybe more. They could light up the whole world with it!

In the radio hut, Stiles goes very, very still.

He snaps his fingers at RADIOMAN #1, who is already spinning the direction-finding antenna.

STILES
(into the mike, calm and friendly)
That's wonderful, Eddie. Tell me more about this sun.

At the edge of the terrace, unseen by Eddie, Wren peeks in through the plane's open hatch. Curious. She doesn't understand what she's watching.

INT. LITTLE AMERICA IV - RADIO HUT - CONTINUOUS

RADIOMAN #1
Got a bearing! Two-one-four degrees!

RADIOMAN #2
(headset to one ear)
Flagship reports a bearing too, sir. One-seven-seven.

Stiles grabs a grease pencil and draws two long lines across a map of Antarctica. They cross in the middle of the blank.

He draws a circle around the X. Twice.

STILES
Get me Washington.

RADIOMAN #1
Sir, it's four in the morning in Wash --

STILES
Get me Washington. Tell them we found it.

EXT. SOLACE - CONTINUOUS

All across the city, the glow of a thousand towers FLARES. Red. Like an alarm. A deep, jarring CHORD shudders through the air.

Ilun everywhere stop and turn toward the landing terrace.

EXT. SOLACE - LANDING TERRACE - CONTINUOUS

Cassor and four GUARDS sweep across the crystal toward the Igloo.

INT. IGLOO - RADIO STATION - CONTINUOUS

EDDIE
...and you should see the gardens, sir, they've got these giant sloths --

A long arm reaches in through the hatch and RIPS the antenna wire out of the radio in a shower of sparks.

Eddie spins around. Cassor fills the hatchway, his light blazing red.

EXT. SOLACE - LANDING TERRACE - MOMENTS LATER

The guards march Eddie out of the plane. Byrd, Frank and Evelyn come running across the terrace.

BYRD
What's going on? What happened?

CASSOR
He has called your soldiers.

EDDIE
No! No, I didn't! I was just reporting in, sir. Every hour on the hour, like we're supposed to.

CASSOR
Reporting to whom?

EDDIE
To... to base.

BYRD
(closing his eyes)
To Stiles.

CASSOR
Your machine shouted our home to the whole sky. And something on the surface listened. We felt it listen. From two places at once.

Eddie's face drains of color as he understands.

EDDIE
The direction finders. Oh no. Oh no, no, no.

CASSOR
(to the guards)
They are confined.

Wren pushes through the crowd, her lights a frantic violet.

WREN
Warden, no! They didn't mean --

CASSOR
Go home, child.

The guards lead the humans away.

Eddie looks back at Byrd. His voice is tiny.

EDDIE
I'm sorry, sir. I didn't think.

BYRD
I know, son. I know.

INT. SOLACE - CRYSTAL CHAMBER - LATER

A beautiful, comfortable room. Soft cushions. A bowl of strange glowing fruit. One doorway, sealed by a shimmering curtain of light that hums when you get near it.

It is still a prison.

Eddie sits in a corner, knees pulled up, face buried in his arms.

Frank paces. Evelyn sits staring at nothing.

FRANK
Every hour on the hour. Who do you think was listening, kid? The Lone Ranger?

EVELYN
Frank.

FRANK
He just handed Stiles a map!

EDDIE
(muffled)
I know.

FRANK
Stiles is gonna come down here with every bomber in the Navy --

EDDIE
(looking up, eyes red)
I KNOW! I know, okay? I know.

Silence. Frank stops pacing. Looks at the kid. Deflates.

He sits down next to Eddie on the floor.

FRANK
...I took a plane up once without permission. In flight school. Buzzed my girlfriend's house.
(beat)
Took the chimney clean off.

EDDIE
(sniffling)
Really?

FRANK
Her father chased me down the street with a rake. We've all done dumb things, kid.
(beat)
You did yours with the best of intentions. Most people can't say that.

Eddie nods. Wipes his nose on his sleeve.

EVELYN
What happens now?

BYRD
Now they decide what we are.

EDDIE
What are we?

Byrd looks at the three of them for a long moment.

BYRD
That's the question, isn't it?

A chiming SOUND. The light curtain in the doorway ripples, then PARTS, just for a moment -- and Wren slips through. The curtain seals behind her.

EVELYN
How did you do that?

WREN
I sang it open. It's not very hard. Nobody ever tries.
(urgent)
Listen. The Council is gathering. Everyone. The Warden will speak.

BYRD
What will he say?

WREN
That we must close the Veil. Forever. Make it so strong that nothing can ever pass through it again, in or out.
(beat)
And that you must stay here. So you can never lead anyone back.

FRANK
Stay. For how long?

Wren's lights flicker violet.

WREN
Forever.

Silence.

For a split second, Evelyn's eyes drift toward the window -- toward the Garden, the scholars, the endless wonders. A scientist's paradise.

Then she looks at Frank. And the moment passes.

Byrd turns away, toward the window. He takes Igloo's collar from his pocket. Turns the tag over in his fingers.

MARIE (V.O.)
(echo, from Boston)
Come home, Dick.

BYRD
(quietly)
I promised my wife.

WREN
The Elder will let you speak to the Council. She has made them agree.
(beat)
Speak well, Bird.

INT. SOLACE - COUNCIL CHAMBER - DAY

An amphitheater so vast it seems to have no ceiling. Rising tiers hold HUNDREDS OF ILUN, their light patterns shifting like the surface of an ocean: blue, gold, red, violet.

At the center of the floor, in a ring of light: Byrd, Frank, Evelyn and Eddie. Irith stands to one side. Cassor stands to the other.

Wren watches from the lowest tier, hands clenched.

CASSOR
(to the chamber)
For ten thousand years we have watched them. I have listened to their singing air since it first began to sing.

His voice rings out, and as he speaks, his light burns redder.

CASSOR (CONT'D)
I learned their language from their war. Their sirens. Their screams. And one day I heard one of their leaders say these words --

He speaks in a perfect imitation of a flat, Midwestern American voice: President Truman's.

CASSOR (CONT'D)
"Sixteen hours ago an American airplane dropped one bomb on Hiroshima."
(beat)
And then I heard their people cheer.

A shudder of red ripples across the tiers.

CASSOR (CONT'D)
Within hours of entering our home, these four used their machine to call out to their soldiers. Already their listening machines have found us. They will come. And they will want the Ember. Because they want every fire they see.

(beat)
I say we close the Veil, and close it forever. And these four stay. So that they can never lead the others here.

An ILUN COUNCILOR rises from the upper tiers, light blazing.

ILUN COUNCILOR
Why only hide? We could do more. With the Ember, we could silence every one of their weapons. Every bomb. Make them cold and dead.

A rumble of agreement. Red light spreads across the chamber like spilled ink.

IRITH
NO.

The word rings out like a struck bell. The chamber falls silent.

IRITH (CONT'D)
We vowed never to hold the fire again. Not to save ourselves. Not for any reason. That vow is the only thing we carried from our world that is worth keeping.

The red light recedes. Slowly.

Irith turns to Byrd.

IRITH (CONT'D)
Admiral Byrd. Speak for your kind.

Byrd steps forward into the light. Hundreds of faces. Hundreds of glowing eyes.

He clears his throat. Straightens his jacket.

BYRD
Members of the... uh... the Council. Distinguished... Ilun...

He stops. Looks down at his hands. Starts again.

BYRD (CONT'D)
I'm not much good at speeches without a newsreel camera. To be honest, I'm not much good at them with one.
(beat)
The Warden's right.

A ripple of surprise in the light around the chamber.

BYRD (CONT'D)
We made that bomb. We'll probably make more of them. We are a young people, and we make terrible mistakes. And sometimes we cheer when we ought to weep.
(beat)
But I've seen men walk into a blizzard to carry a stranger home. I've seen a nineteen-year-old kid sit up forty-one nights in a row listening to a sound nobody else thought mattered.

Eddie looks up.

BYRD (CONT'D)
I've seen a woman that half the Navy laughed at turn out to be right about everything.

Evelyn's chin lifts.

BYRD (CONT'D)
And I've seen a pilot who was so scared of the light that he couldn't close his eyes fly straight into it anyway, because an old man asked him to.

Frank holds Byrd's gaze.

BYRD (CONT'D)
We're not one thing. We are every thing. That's what makes us dangerous.
(beat)
And that's what makes us worth knowing.

The light across the chamber shifts. Uncertain. Some gold. Much red.

CASSOR
Pretty words. Your world is very good at pretty words.

BYRD
You're right about that too, Warden.

He reaches into his flight bag and pulls out two things: his CAMERA, and his leather-bound FLIGHT LOG.

BYRD (CONT'D)
All my life I've wanted to be first. First to fly over the North Pole. First over the South Pole. First to see what nobody else has seen.
(beat)
And all my life there's been a whisper. That I never really made it to the North Pole. That I turned back short, and fudged my numbers, and lied about it.
(beat)
I've spent twenty years trying to prove that whisper wrong.

He holds up the camera.

BYRD (CONT'D)
This film holds the greatest discovery in the history of the world. And this log holds the way to find it. With these, nobody would ever doubt Dick Byrd again. Not ever.

He pops open the back of the camera.

He pulls the FILM out into the golden light. All of it. Unspooling it, foot by foot, exposing every frame.

Evelyn gasps. Eddie half-rises.

A wave of bright, shocked light ripples through the tiers.

Byrd lets the ruined film fall to the crystal floor. Then he opens the flight log, finds the page with the coordinates, and tears it out.

He walks across the floor and puts the page in Irith's hand.

BYRD (CONT'D)
Now there's no proof. There's just my word.
(beat)
I'm told your people can always see whether someone means what they say. Mine can't. We have to decide to trust each other.
(turning to the chamber)
So I'm asking you. Decide.

Silence. Absolute silence.

Irith looks at the page in her hand. Her silver light deepens, warms, turns to gold.

She turns to face the Council.

Slowly -- tier by tier, face by face -- GOLD light begins to spread across the chamber. Like dawn rolling across a sea.

But not everywhere. Patches of red remain. Cassor's brightest of all.

IRITH
The Council has chosen. You will return home, Richard Byrd. And when you have passed through, the Veil will close behind you.

The crew breathes again. Eddie grabs Frank's arm. Evelyn closes her eyes.

CASSOR
Words, Elder. They are only words. Their whole world runs on words.

IRITH
So does ours, Warden.
(beat)
We simply glow when we speak them.

She turns to Byrd.

BYRD
Thank you.

IRITH
Do not thank me.
(beat)
Keep your word.

EXT. SOLACE - LANDING TERRACE - DAY

Preparations. Ilun TECHNICIANS swarm around the Igloo, its broken antenna mended with a thread of glowing crystal.

One TECHNICIAN fills the plane's fuel tanks from a floating, shimmering vessel. She sniffs the fuel. Her lights curdle green.

ILUN TECHNICIAN
We made more of your liquid. As close as we could. This is truly what you drink?

FRANK
The plane drinks it.

ILUN TECHNICIAN
(patting the Igloo's nose sympathetically)
Poor plane.

Evelyn stands at the terrace edge, looking out toward the distant Garden of the Lost. Memorizing it.

Eddie sits on the Igloo's wing, glumly polishing his harmonica. Wren drops down beside him.

WREN
You are sad.

EDDIE
I'm the reason you have to close your door forever.

WREN
The door was always going to close. You just made it close faster.
(beat)
Play me the river song again. Before you go.

Eddie raises the harmonica.

INT. LITTLE AMERICA IV - RADIO HUT - DAY

Stiles stands over the map, staring at the circled X.

LT. GRADY (30s), a weathered Navy pilot in a fur parka, stands before him, uneasy.

LT. GRADY
Sir, the weather's closing in. That's six hundred miles past the Pole. If the Admiral's plane went down out there --

STILES
The Admiral's plane didn't go down, Lieutenant. It went somewhere.
(tapping the X)
Fly to these coordinates. Photograph everything. That's an order from Washington.

Grady looks at the X. Swallows.

LT. GRADY
Aye, sir.

EXT. ANTARCTIC PLATEAU - THE VEIL - DAY

A second R4D, nose painted with the name "MISS ALABAMA," bores through the sky toward the shimmering curtain of light.

INT. MISS ALABAMA - COCKPIT - CONTINUOUS

Lt. Grady and a CO-PILOT stare through the windshield at the colossal Veil.

CO-PILOT
Mother of pearl.

The Veil FLARES as they approach. A wave of violent light. The plane BUCKS. Every instrument spins.

The light seems to PUSH them -- gently, but irresistibly -- like a giant hand turning them around.

LT. GRADY
I can't hold her! She won't go in!

The plane swings around in a wide arc, back the way it came.

INT. SOLACE - THE VEIL CHAMBER - CONTINUOUS

A tall, narrow chamber of dark crystal. In its center, a pillar of swirling light: a living map of the Veil.

Inside the light, a tiny dark shape -- the Miss Alabama -- bounces off the curtain and turns away.

Cassor watches it, his red light blazing.

CASSOR
(to himself)
Already they come. Not even one day.

He turns to a circle of ILUN SINGERS standing around the pillar.

CASSOR (CONT'D)
Seal it.

ILUN SINGER
Warden, the Council said after the humans have passed --

CASSOR
The Council trusts words. I trust what I see. Their soldiers are at our door. SEAL IT. NOW.

The singers hesitate. Then begin to HUM: a deep, dark, grinding chord.

The light in the pillar begins to change. To thicken. To darken.

In the doorway behind them, unseen, Wren watches in horror.

She turns and RUNS.

EXT. SOLACE - LANDING TERRACE - DAY

Eddie is halfway through "Shenandoah" when Wren comes tearing across the terrace, lights blazing every color at once.

WREN
BIRD! BIRD!

Byrd turns from the Igloo's cockpit ladder.

WREN (CONT'D)
The Warden is closing the Veil! Now! Not after -- NOW!

BYRD
The Council said --

WREN
Another of your flying machines came to the Veil. The Warden saw it. He thinks your soldiers are already here. If you don't go now, you will never go!

Byrd looks up toward the Throat. Far above, the sky around the opening is DARKENING. Storm clouds boil where there were none.

BYRD
FRANK!

But Frank is already sprinting for the plane. Evelyn grabs her instruments. Eddie shoves his harmonica in his pocket and vaults off the wing.

Elder Irith appears on the terrace, gliding quickly, guards behind her.

IRITH
Go. Quickly. I will try to reason with him.

BYRD
Elder --

IRITH
You have a promise to keep, Richard. Two of them, I think.

Byrd takes her long hand in both of his. Just for a second.

Then he climbs into the plane.

INT. IGLOO - COCKPIT - CONTINUOUS

Frank slams switches. The engines cough and catch. Propellers blur.

FRANK
Fuel's full. Whatever they put in there, the engines like it.

EDDIE
(at the radio)
Radio's alive!

EVELYN
Everybody strapped in? Good. Let's leave.

EXT. SOLACE - LANDING TERRACE - CONTINUOUS

The Igloo roars across the crystal terrace and lifts into the golden sky.

Wren leaps into her glass-leaf skiff.

IRITH
Wren! Wren, no --

WREN
They don't know the way through! I'll come back! I PROMISE!

The skiff shoots off after the plane like a spark.

EXT. THE HIDDEN REALM - SKY - CONTINUOUS

The Igloo races over the Garden of the Lost. Below, the mammoths raise their trunks. The passenger pigeons scatter in a great swirling cloud.

The skiff pulls up alongside the cockpit window. Wren waves frantically: FOLLOW ME.

INT. IGLOO - COCKPIT - CONTINUOUS

FRANK
I'm following the glowing kid in the glass leaf. Just so everyone knows. That's our navigation plan.

BYRD
Best navigator I've had since Igloo.

EXT. THE THROAT - CONTINUOUS

The Igloo and the skiff dive into the mouth of the great spiral canyon and start to CLIMB.

But the Throat has changed. The warm golden light is fading. Storm clouds churn down its walls. Snow swirls in the air. Ice crystals form out of nothing.

And everywhere -- huge curtains of crackling AURORA-LIGHTNING sweep across the canyon like scythes.

INT. IGLOO - COCKPIT - CONTINUOUS

The temperature needle drops. Seventy. Fifty. Thirty.

Ice begins to crawl across the windshield.

A curtain of lightning rips across their path. Frank banks hard -- the Igloo screams around it, wingtip nearly brushing the canyon wall.

EVELYN
It's getting narrower. The whole Throat is closing!

FRANK
I noticed, Doc!

EXT. THE THROAT - CONTINUOUS

Three of Cassor's SEED-CRAFT swoop in from above, their lights pulsing red. They spread out across the canyon ahead, blocking the way. Herding.

Wren's skiff darts between them, a gold spark weaving through the red.

INT. IGLOO - COCKPIT - CONTINUOUS

A seed-craft looms in the windshield. Frank yanks the yoke. The plane rolls, passengers slammed sideways.

FLASH. A sheet of white aurora-light explodes directly in front of the plane.

The cockpit goes WHITE.

And Frank FREEZES.

FLASH CUT TO:

EXT. BIKINI ATOLL - SKY - DAY (FLASHBACK)

WHITE. The radio screaming. Hands that can't be seen.

BACK TO SCENE

INT. IGLOO - COCKPIT - CONTINUOUS

Frank's hands are locked on the yoke. Eyes wide. Not breathing. The plane is drifting toward the canyon wall.

EVELYN
Frank!

BYRD
Frank, talk to me!

FRANK
It's white. It's all white. I can't see. I can't see anything, I can't --

BYRD
Then don't look.

FRANK
What?

BYRD
Close your eyes, Frank. Don't look. Listen.
(over his shoulder)
Eddie! Can you get the girl on the radio?

Eddie spins dials. Static. Static. Then --

WREN (V.O.)
(through the radio)
...Bird? Bird, can you hear me?

BYRD
We hear you, Wren! We can't see! Can you guide us?

WREN (V.O.)
I'll sing you the way! When the song goes up, you go up! When it goes down, you go down!

And through the radio, Wren begins to SING. Not words -- just the melody. Clear and high and bright.

"Shenandoah."

Frank closes his eyes.

The melody RISES. Frank pulls back on the yoke. The Igloo climbs -- and a lightning curtain slashes through the space

where it just was.

The melody FALLS. Frank pushes forward. The plane dives under a seed-craft.

The melody SWEEPS to one side. Frank banks.

His eyes are closed. His face is calm. For the first time in a year, Frank Delaney is flying blind, and he isn't afraid.

EVELYN
(reading off the instruments, steady as a rock)
Airspeed one-forty. Altitude climbing. Wall's two hundred yards to port.

EDDIE
Left engine! The left engine's icing up!

Out the side window: the LEFT ENGINE coughs black smoke. Shudders. Its propeller slows... and STOPS.

BYRD
Feather it!

FRANK
(eyes still closed)
Feathering. We're on one engine, folks.

EDDIE
Is that bad?

FRANK
It's not good, kid.

EXT. THE THROAT - THE GATE - CONTINUOUS

The top of the Throat. The very last gap before the Veil seals for good: a narrowing ring of grey daylight, shrinking like the pupil of an eye.

And hovering in the center of the gap, blocking it completely, is the largest seed-craft we've seen. Armored in dark crystal. Glowing red.

CASSOR.

INT. IGLOO - COCKPIT - CONTINUOUS

Frank opens his eyes. Sees the craft dead ahead.

FRANK
Sir --

BYRD
Hold your course.

FRANK
He's not moving!

BYRD
Hold your course, Frank.

INT. CASSOR'S CRAFT - CONTINUOUS

A cockpit of dark crystal. Cassor stands at its center, both hands raised, his whole body blazing red -- holding the Veil's power. Straining to close it.

Wren's skiff rockets up beside his craft.

WREN (V.O.)
Warden! Let them through!

CASSOR
Their soldiers are already at our door, child!

INT. IGLOO - COCKPIT - INTERCUT

Wren's voice fills the Igloo's radio too. She is speaking in English so that everyone can hear.

WREN (V.O.)
That was not him! That was NOT HIM! He gave you his proof! He burned the thing he wanted most in all his life, and he gave you his word! What more do you WANT?

CASSOR (V.O.)
Words!

WREN (V.O.)
Then decide to trust him! That is what they do! That is ALL they do! They decide!

Through the iced windshield, Byrd can see Cassor now: a tall figure inside the dark crystal craft, burning red, two hundred yards away and closing fast.

Byrd lets go of his armrest. He sits up straight.

And he SALUTES. A crisp, perfect, old-fashioned Navy salute. Held. Steady.

INT. CASSOR'S CRAFT - CONTINUOUS

Cassor sees it. A human, in a tiny metal machine, flying straight at him on one engine, saluting.

His light flickers.

Red.

Red.

...Gold.

Cassor lowers his hands.

Then he raises them again -- but now he PUSHES OUTWARD, and the dark craft rises out of the gap, and the narrowing ring of daylight STOPS shrinking.

He's holding the Veil OPEN. His whole body trembling with the effort, his light blazing gold.

CASSOR
(through gritted teeth)
GO.

EXT. THE THROAT - THE GATE - CONTINUOUS

The crippled Igloo, one propeller dead, roars up through the ring of daylight with the skiff at its side --

-- and bursts through the Veil.

EXT. ANTARCTIC PLATEAU - DAY

Clean, cold air. Blinding white ice stretching to every horizon. The sun hanging low, golden, just above the edge of the world.

The Igloo levels out above the ice, limping on one engine. The skiff pulls up alongside it, right beside the cockpit window.

INT./EXT. IGLOO - COCKPIT / WREN'S SKIFF - CONTINUOUS

Byrd slides open the little side window. Freezing wind howls in.

Wren is staring at the outside world for the first time. The endless ice. The enormous, open, blue sky -- a sky that doesn't curve. A sky with no ceiling.

Her lights shimmer pale blue with awe.

WREN
It's so... BIG.

Then she cranes her neck, searching the sky. Puzzled. Then disappointed.

WREN (CONT'D)
Bird. Where are the stars?

BYRD
(shouting over the wind)
They're up there! Hiding behind the sun! It's summer here -- the sun won't set for days!
(beat)
Give them a little while!

Wren's lights fade to a sad violet. But she nods. She understands.

Behind her, the Veil shimmers. Darkens. It is closing.

Byrd digs in his jacket pocket and pulls out a small, battered brass POCKET COMPASS.

BYRD (CONT'D)
Here! Take this!

He holds it out the window. Wren swoops close and takes it. Turns it over in her long fingers. The needle swings, settles.

BYRD (CONT'D)
I've had it since the North Pole. It points north. Away from the bottom of the world. Toward the stars.
(beat)
Someday, it'll show you where to look.

Wren clutches it to her chest. Her lights glow gold.

She reaches into the skiff and pulls out something small: a SEED. Round, smooth, the size of an acorn, glowing with a faint, warm, golden light from inside.

WREN
From the Garden. So you remember.

She tosses it. Byrd catches it.

From the Veil behind her comes a long, low CHORD. Irith's voice, from very far away:

IRITH (V.O.)
Wren. Come home.

Wren looks at Byrd one last time.

WREN
Goodbye, Bird.

BYRD
Goodbye, Wren.

The skiff peels away and DIVES back toward the Veil --

EXT. THE VEIL - CONTINUOUS

-- and slips through the last tiny gap of daylight, a single gold spark --

-- an instant before the Veil SEALS with a sound like a great door closing. BOOM.

The curtain of light shimmers. Fades. Dims.

And then it's gone. Where it was, there is nothing but a faint haze over the endless ice. As if it was never there at all.

INT. IGLOO - COCKPIT - CONTINUOUS

Silence. Just the drone of one engine.

Byrd slides the window shut. He opens his hand and looks at the glowing seed. Then he tucks it into his breast pocket, over his heart.

EDDIE
(quietly)
Sir. Where are we?

Evelyn holds a sextant up to the low sun. Squints. Checks her watch. Does the math on her knee.

EVELYN
About seven hundred miles from Little America. Give or take.

FRANK
On one engine. With half a tank.

EVELYN
(beat)
Give or take.

INT. IGLOO - COCKPIT - LATER

The ice slides by below, endless and pink in the late light. Frank flies. Evelyn navigates. Eddie works on the radio.

The radio CRACKLES.

STILES (V.O.)
...Igloo, Igloo, this is Little America. Igloo, do you read? Report your position and your findings.

Eddie freezes, his hand on the microphone. He looks at Byrd.

Byrd looks back at him. Says nothing. It's Eddie's call.

Eddie takes a breath. Keys the mike. His voice is steady and tired and perfectly ordinary.

EDDIE
Little America, Igloo. We read you.
(beat)
We, uh, got turned around in a magnetic storm. Compass went crazy. Pretty sure we've been flying in circles for two days.
(beat)
Sir, about my last transmission. I think I was a little loopy from the altitude. No sleep, no food... you know how it is. Nothing out here but ice. Over.

INT. LITTLE AMERICA IV - RADIO HUT - INTERCUT

Stiles stares at the radio.

STILES
Say again, Igloo?

EDDIE
Nothing but ice, sir. Lots and lots of ice.
(beat)
Request a hot meal on arrival. Igloo out.

He clicks off.

In the radio hut, Stiles sets down his microphone very, very carefully.

INT. IGLOO - COCKPIT - CONTINUOUS

Eddie stares at the radio, stunned at himself.

EDDIE
First lie I ever told on the radio, sir.

BYRD
It was a good one.

FRANK
Kid, you're a natural.

EDDIE
Is that a compliment?

FRANK
Not even a little bit.

Evelyn suddenly sits up. Points out the windshield.

EVELYN
Look.

EXT. ANTARCTIC PLATEAU - SKY - CONTINUOUS

The great golden sun, which has circled the sky without setting for four months, touches the edge of the world.

It slides, slowly, below the horizon.

The sky turns rose. Then lavender. Then a deep, glowing violet.

INT. IGLOO - COCKPIT - CONTINUOUS

EVELYN
The first sunset of the year. The sun's been up since October.

They watch in silence as the sky deepens.

And then, low in the violet, a single point of light appears. Bright and steady.

BYRD
There. The first star of the season.
(beat)
Canopus.

EDDIE
What's a Canopus?

BYRD
The old Greeks named it after a ship's pilot. A helmsman who steered his king's whole fleet home.

He looks over at Frank. Frank, flying on one engine through the dusk, eyes open, calm.

BYRD (CONT'D)
Take us home, helmsman.

FRANK
Aye, sir.

EXT. LITTLE AMERICA IV - RUNWAY - DUSK

Floodlights. Flares. Every man in the camp has turned out onto the ice.

The Igloo glides in out of the violet sky, one propeller dead, the other coughing. It hits the snow hard, bounces, skids sideways across the runway, and slides to a stop in a spray of powder twenty feet from the radio hut.

The last engine sputters... and dies. Out of fuel.

The crowd ROARS.

EXT. LITTLE AMERICA IV - RUNWAY - MOMENTS LATER

The crew stumbles out of the plane into a crush of cheering MEN, back-slaps, blankets, hot coffee.

Stiles cuts through the crowd like a knife.

STILES
Admiral. Your flight log. And your film.

Byrd hands him both without a word.

Stiles flips open the log. Pages and pages of routine notes, times, headings. And then a jagged edge where a page has been torn out.

He opens the camera. Empty.

STILES (CONT'D)
Where's the page, Admiral?

BYRD
Must have blown out the window.

STILES
And the film?

BYRD
Camera froze. Happens all the time down here.

Stiles steps close. Speaks low, so only Byrd can hear.

STILES
I heard what I heard.

BYRD
And I flew what I flew.

STILES
This isn't over. You'll answer to Washington.

BYRD
I usually do.

Stiles turns on his heel and walks away.

INT. LITTLE AMERICA IV - SCIENCE HUT - NIGHT

Evelyn switches on her wire recorder. Puts on her headphones. Listens.

Static. Only static.

She checks the magnetometer. The needle sits perfectly still.

EVELYN
(softly)
It's gone. The anomaly. The hum. All of it.

Byrd, in the doorway, nods.

BYRD
They closed the door.

He touches his breast pocket. Through the fabric: a faint, warm glow.

INT. PENTAGON - CONFERENCE ROOM - DAY

SUPER: "THE PENTAGON - WASHINGTON, D.C. - MARCH 11, 1947"

A long table. GENERALS and ADMIRALS in a haze of cigarette smoke. Prescott at the head.

Stiles stands before an easel holding a map of Antarctica. Two grease-pencil lines cross in the middle of the blank.

STILES
Gentlemen. Admiral Byrd's own radioman described a hidden region beneath the ice. A city. And an energy source more powerful than anything on Earth.

(tapping the map)
Two independent radio bearings place it here.

AN AIR FORCE GENERAL leans forward.

AIR FORCE GENERAL
If that's real, it's the most important strategic discovery of the century.

All eyes turn to Byrd, sitting alone at the far end of the table in his dress uniform, composed.

BYRD
Gentlemen. We flew in circles for two days inside a magnetic storm. Every instrument we had was useless. My radioman was nineteen years old and hadn't slept in thirty hours.
(beat)
Radio bearings at the bottom of the world bounce off the aurora like a rubber ball. Any radioman will tell you. That X could be off by five hundred miles.

STILES
Then you won't object if we send a squadron to check.

BYRD
Into the polar winter? Total darkness, sixty below, winds that'll tear the wings off a bomber? You'll lose every plane and every man.
(to the table)
And you'll be the ones who have to explain that to their mothers.

The brass shift uneasily. Prescott studies Byrd with narrowed eyes.

INT. PENTAGON - CORRIDOR - LATER

Byrd walks the endless corridor alone. Footsteps catch up behind him.

STILES
Admiral.

Byrd keeps walking. Stiles falls into step.

STILES (CONT'D)
You hold a press conference tomorrow. The whole country will be listening.
(beat)
Here's what you're going to tell them. That Operation Highjump discovered a site of great strategic importance beyond the South Pole. One that requires an immediate follow-up military expedition.

BYRD
And if I don't?

STILES
Radioman Navarro will be court-martialed for unauthorized transmission of classified information. Commander Delaney will lose his wings. Permanently. And Dr. March will never work for the government of the United States again. I'll see to it.

Byrd stops walking.

STILES (CONT'D)
And then there's you.
(beat)
You know what they've always said, Admiral. That you never made the North Pole in twenty-six. That you turned back and cooked your numbers.
(beat)
Tomorrow, you can tell the truth and be remembered as the greatest explorer in history. Or I will make sure the history books remember you as a fraud.

Byrd looks at him for a long time.

BYRD
You really believe all this, don't you, Mr. Stiles? That you're protecting people.

STILES
I know I am.

BYRD
That's what worries me.

(beat)
I'll see you at the press conference.

He walks away down the corridor.

INT. HOTEL ROOM - WASHINGTON, D.C. - NIGHT

A modest hotel room. Rain on the windows.

Marie sits on the bed, very still, holding the glowing SEED in her cupped hands. Its warm gold light flickers across her face.

Byrd sits across from her, tie loosened, looking ten years older and ten years younger at the same time.

He has told her everything. We can see it in her eyes.

MARIE
A dodo.

BYRD
Stole a boy's chewing gum. Swallowed it whole.

Marie laughs. Then the laugh catches in her throat, and she has to press the back of her hand against her mouth.

MARIE
You kept your promise. You told me first.

BYRD
You're the only one who'll ever know. All of it.

She looks down at the seed.

MARIE
What will you say tomorrow?

BYRD
If I tell the truth, the whole world goes down there with bombers. If I say nothing, Stiles destroys my crew, and then he destroys me.
(beat)
There's no right answer, Marie.

MARIE
Dick. You've been talking to newspapermen for twenty years. You know better than anyone how to tell the truth in a way nobody believes.

He looks up at her.

MARIE (CONT'D)
So the question isn't what you'll say.
(beat)
It's what you care about more. Being believed? Or being right?

Byrd is quiet for a long time.

BYRD
I always thought those were the same thing.

MARIE
I know you did, darling.

She closes his hand around the glowing seed.

MARIE (CONT'D)
They're not.

INT. NAVY DEPARTMENT - PRESS ROOM - DAY

The room is PACKED. Wall-to-wall REPORTERS in fedoras with press cards in their hatbands. Newsreel cameras on tripods. A thicket of RADIO MICROPHONES crowds the podium, wires snaking across the floor. Flashbulbs pop like fireworks.

Behind the podium, in a row of chairs: Frank in dress uniform. Eddie in his dress blues, scrubbed pink, terrified. Evelyn in a sharp grey suit, chin high.

Marie sits in the front row of the audience.

At the side of the room: Prescott and a cluster of BRASS.

At the very back, leaning against the wall, arms folded: Stiles.

Byrd steps up to the podium. The room hushes. Flashbulbs flare.

BYRD
Good afternoon, gentlemen. And ladies.

A young female reporter, PEGGY FAIRFAX (20s), sharp as a tack, raises her pencil in acknowledgment.

INT. SOLACE - THE LISTENING POOL - SAME

A small, round chamber with a pool of rippling light at its center. Within the pool, sounds and voices shimmer and echo: the "singing air." Radio.

Wren kneels at the edge, clutching Byrd's brass compass. Irith sits beside her. And standing apart, arms folded, his armor dull: Cassor.

From the pool comes Byrd's voice.

BYRD (V.O.)
(through the pool, faintly)
...thank you all for coming.

WREN
It's him! It's Bird!

INT. NAVY DEPARTMENT - PRESS ROOM - CONTINUOUS

Byrd reads from a prepared statement.

BYRD
Operation Highjump has been the largest expedition ever sent to the Antarctic. We have charted coastlines no human being has ever seen and taken tens of thousands of aerial photographs. I am proud of every man who served.
(lowering the paper)
But I'd like to say a word about three people in particular.

He turns toward the row of chairs behind him.

BYRD (CONT'D)
Lieutenant Commander Frank Delaney. He flew my aircraft home through the worst storm I have seen in four expeditions, the last seven hundred miles on one engine. He is the finest pilot I have ever flown with, and the bravest man I know.

Frank stares straight ahead. His jaw works.

BYRD (CONT'D)
Radioman Second Class Edward Navarro. When every instrument we had failed, he kept us in contact with the world. He's nineteen years old. Remember his name. You'll be hearing it.

Eddie turns bright red.

BYRD (CONT'D)
And Dr. Evelyn March of the Naval Research Laboratory. She is the finest scientist I have ever served with. And if the United States Navy has any sense at all, it will give her a laboratory of her own, and then get out of her way.

The reporters APPLAUD. Flashbulbs explode over the crew. Pencils fly across notebooks.

At the back of the room, Stiles' jaw tightens. He understands exactly what Byrd has just done. Three national heroes, on the record. Untouchable.

BYRD (CONT'D)
I'll take your questions.

A forest of hands. Byrd points.

REPORTER #1
Admiral, did you reach the South Pole again?

BYRD
We did. It's still there.

Laughter.

Then a man in a brown suit near the back stands up. HOLLIS (40s). He glances at Stiles. Stiles gives him the smallest nod.

HOLLIS
Admiral. Bob Hollis, Washington Courier. There are reports that during your final flight, your radioman described a hidden land beyond the Pole. Green valleys. Warm air.
(beat)
A city.

The room goes QUIET.

HOLLIS (CONT'D)
Is it true, Admiral? Did you discover a hidden land?

Every pencil stops. Every camera turns.

INT. SOLACE - THE LISTENING POOL - CONTINUOUS

Wren grips the compass so hard her fingers glow. Irith goes still. Cassor turns his head toward the pool for the first time.

INT. NAVY DEPARTMENT - PRESS ROOM - CONTINUOUS

Byrd looks at his crew. Frank. Eddie. Evelyn.

At Marie, in the front row. She looks back at him. Steady.

At Stiles, at the back of the room. Waiting.

Byrd's hand drifts to his breast pocket. Through the fabric, the faintest warm glow.

A long, long beat.

BYRD
Gentlemen. I have been to the bottom of the world four times.
(beat)
And I will tell you what I found there.

Silence.

BYRD (CONT'D)
I found a land of wonder beyond the Pole.

A murmur. Pencils start scribbling furiously. At the back, Stiles straightens, a flicker of triumph in his eyes.

BYRD (CONT'D)
A land where the ice sings. A land that has kept, for thousands of years, the things the rest of the world has lost.
(beat)
It has no army. It has no flag.
(beat)
And I pray to God it never will.

The scribbling slows. The reporters glance at each other. Is this news? Or poetry?

Byrd folds his prepared statement and sets it aside.

BYRD (CONT'D)
Last summer, our country set off two atomic bombs over the Pacific Ocean. Five, all told, since the first. Once in a desert. Twice over cities. Twice upon the sea.

INT. SOLACE - THE LISTENING POOL - CONTINUOUS

Irith's eyes widen. Her own words, coming back to her across the world.

INT. NAVY DEPARTMENT - PRESS ROOM - CONTINUOUS

BYRD
Every one of them is felt farther away than any of us knows.
(beat)
I have spent my life in the Antarctic. And I believe with all my heart that it should belong to no nation's army. Let it belong to science. Let it belong to peace.
(beat)
Let it be the one place on this Earth where we never, ever bring the fire.

Total silence.

Then Peggy Fairfax, the young reporter, begins to CLAP. Then another reporter. Then a dozen. Then the whole room.

At the side of the room, Prescott and the brass exchange uneasy glances. Applause for a peace speech from America's most beloved explorer. Try sending a bomber squadron after that.

Hollis, desperate, shouts over the applause:

HOLLIS
But the city, Admiral! The green valleys! Did you or did you not see a city?

The room quiets. Byrd smiles. The old showman's smile.

BYRD
Son, after fifteen hours in a cockpit at forty below zero, a man sees all kinds of things.
(beat)
My radioman swears a dodo bird stole his chewing gum.

The room EXPLODES with laughter.

Eddie, from his chair behind the podium, leans toward the microphones:

EDDIE
It was a really big dodo, sir.

Even bigger laughter. Flashbulbs pop.

PEGGY FAIRFAX
Commander Delaney! Did you see a city?

Frank leans forward. Absolutely deadpan.

FRANK
Ma'am, I saw a whole lot of white.

Laughter. Then:

PEGGY FAIRFAX
Dr. March? As a scientist?

EVELYN
As a scientist, I can tell you that the Antarctic is the most extraordinary place on Earth.
(beat)
And we have barely seen any of it.

At the back of the room, Stiles closes his eyes. It's over. And he knows it.

INT. SOLACE - THE LISTENING POOL - CONTINUOUS

Laughter echoes from the pool. Wren is laughing too, her lights dancing gold and pink.

Cassor stares at the pool. His armor, his whole body, is slowly glowing gold.

CASSOR
(very quietly)
He kept his word.

IRITH
He did.

Wren looks up at Cassor. Hopeful.

IRITH (CONT'D)
Warden. When the long night comes to the surface, open a window in the Veil. Just a small one.

(beat)
Let the children see the stars.

Cassor looks down at Wren. At the compass in her hands.

For a long moment, he says nothing.

CASSOR
Yes, Elder.

Wren throws her arms around his armored waist. Cassor stiffens, appalled.

Then, awkwardly, he pats her on the head.

INT. NAVY DEPARTMENT - PRESS ROOM - CONTINUOUS

The press conference is breaking up. Reporters rush for the telephones. Byrd steps down from the podium. Marie meets him and takes his arm. The crew falls in around him.

At the door, the young reporter Peggy Fairfax steps into his path, notebook closed.

PEGGY FAIRFAX
Admiral. Off the record.
(beat)
Was any of it real?

Byrd puts on his hat. He looks at Marie. Then back at Peggy.

BYRD
Off the record?
(beat)
Every word.

He tips his hat to her and walks out the door.

Peggy stares after him. Then she opens her notebook and begins to write.

FLASH --

FREEZE FRAME on a newspaper front page, spinning up toward camera and slamming to a stop:

INSERT - NEWSPAPER HEADLINE

"BYRD SEES 'LAND OF WONDER' BEYOND THE POLE"

EXT. NAVY DEPARTMENT - STEPS - DUSK

Byrd and Marie descend the long stone steps arm in arm. Frank, Evelyn and Eddie a few steps behind them. Frank and Evelyn are holding hands now, and not hiding it. Eddie notices and rolls his eyes.

Stiles comes out the door behind them, hat in hand. A CIG AIDE intercepts him with a telegram.

CIG AIDE
New assignment from the Director, sir. Some rancher in New Mexico keeps calling about strange lights in the sky.

Stiles reads the telegram. Lets out a long, weary sigh.

Byrd stops at the bottom of the steps and looks up.

The sky over Washington is deepening to violet. And there, low over the Capitol dome, is the first star of the evening.

Byrd starts to hum. Softly. "Shenandoah."

Marie leans her head on his shoulder.

The camera rises slowly past them, up and up, into the darkening sky, as the stars come out, one by one, and then by thousands.

FADE OUT.

TITLE CARD:

Rear Admiral Richard E. Byrd made his final voyage to Antarctica in 1955-56.

He died in 1957, one of the most celebrated explorers in American history.

In 1959, twelve nations signed the Antarctic Treaty, setting aside the continent for peace and science, and forbidding military bases and nuclear explosions there.

It remains in force today.

The land beyond the Pole has never been found.

MID-CREDITS SCENE

EXT. THE VEIL - THE WINDOW - NIGHT

SUPER: "THE POLAR NIGHT - JUNE 1947"

Darkness. Wind. The ice glows faintly blue.

In the side of a great ridge of ice, a small round WINDOW of light opens, like an eye.

Out of it, cautiously, step a handful of ILUN CHILDREN, wrapped in shimmering cloaks. Elder Irith follows. And behind her, standing guard at the window, his armor glowing a quiet gold: Cassor.

And first, ahead of them all: Wren.

She walks out onto the ice. She looks up.

And there they are.

THE STARS. Thousands upon thousands of them, more than anyone could ever count, blazing across a sky as black as ink. And across them, rippling from one horizon to the other in vast, silent curtains of green and red: the AURORA AUSTRALIS, dancing.

Wren's lights flare in every color there is. Around her, the other children's lights do the same, until the little group on the ice glows like a handful of stars fallen to Earth.

Wren opens her hand. Byrd's brass compass. The needle trembles, swings... and settles. Pointing north. Across the ice. Across the ocean. Toward someone very far away.

She looks north for a long time.

Then, very softly, she begins to hum. "Shenandoah."

One by one, the other children join in. Then Irith. And finally -- reluctantly, quietly, but unmistakably -- Cassor.

Their song rises into the dancing light.

FADE OUT.

THE END